

Fundamentals of PHP

2.1 Variables:

A variable can hold a value that can be changed during the course of the execution of the script. The values can either be explicitly changed or by performing some operation on it. They are similar to variables you used back in school Algebra.

Let's look at the syntax of a PHP variable:

```
$variable_name = Value;
```

Example:

```
<?php
$learning = "Learning Variable!";
$x_numeral = 8;
$first_name = 'John';
$lastName = 'Denver';
$nextNumeral = 16;
?>
```

Here, we have inserted a variable name and set the value as per our need. The second line of the program with '\$learning' variable ends with a semicolon (;) to mark the closing of the statement "Learning Variable". The quotation mark (" "), inserted in the second line, is not used in the second variable ('\$x_numeral') as it is an integer.

PHP is a case sensitive programming language. Here '\$x_numeral' variable differs from the variable '\$X_numeral' because of the use of small 'x' in the first variable and capital 'X' in the second variable. The dollar sign (\$) at the beginning of the variable is important as it is exclusively used in PHP. It instructs the PHP engine that the inserted code with this dollar sign is a variable. A variable in PHP always starts with an underscore '_' or with a letter (x, X). You cannot begin a variable with a number. It is a common practice to separate variable names with underscore